day in December 2009 that ‘the process of forming the state of Telangana was being initiated’, an impulsive decision that would eventually mark the beginning of the end for the Congress in Andhra Pradesh.

Among the various theories mooted for the Telangana midnight announcement, two were particularly amusing—first, that some party loyalists wanted to give Sonia Gandhi, who had committed to Telangana in the election campaign, a ‘birthday gift’ (her birthday is on 9 December); second, that Rahul Gandhi had a fetish for small states and had drawn up a map of India which mirrored the United States with fifty states! The truth is that an Intelligence Bureau (IB) report claimed that there would be a possible ‘bloodbath’ in Hyderabad if Telangana was not announced. Pro-Telangana protestors, the IB report stated, had been infiltrated by Maoists who planned to march to the secretariat the next morning. The Centre, quite simply, panicked.

With that one midnight decision, the Congress lost control of the political situation in a critical state. Y.S. Rajasekhar Reddy had held the Congress together; without him at the helm, the party was falling apart and the Telangana decision mirrored a mind in turmoil. Andhra was lost, perhaps for good.

Some observers have attributed Sonia’s relatively less dominating role in UPA-II to her health problems—she had to travel abroad frequently for a health condition that no one would confirm (we once put out a news flash that Mrs Gandhi had gone for treatment to Sloane Kettering, the world’s oldest and largest private care cancer centre, only to be warned by Patel that we would be sued for putting out false information).

Others suggest that Sonia, like a doting Italian (or rather Indian) mother, was desperately keen to step aside so that Rahul could play a greater role and take control of the Congress party. The Congress was, after all, in her world view, a dynastical party whose past, present and future were tied to her family. Her critics say she was always a ‘lucky’ leader with limited political skills, and that her luck was always bound to run out one day.

The more logical explanation is that with the UPA government being buffeted by multiple crises, a sense of drift, fatigue and eventually,